

GIRISH GV



SAFFRON SWEEP: Yeddyurappa with Advani (left), Rajnath Singh (right) and other BJP leaders

ect a chief ministerial candidate that the verdict had gone against it. The suave S.M. Krishna emerged from his residence at around two in the afternoon to concede defeat. His is probably the biggest loss. Having given up his post as governor of Maharashtra two months ago in the hope that he would be projected as chief minister, Krishna did not even contest the elections here. Internal bickering definitely did the Congress in.

As for the winning party, a few hours saw a complete turnaround in attitudes. Yeddyurappa, along with leaders M. Venkaiah Naidu and Ananth Kumar, had promised to be accessible on the counting day. On May 25, however, the leaders decided to quietly watch the proceedings in the Taj West End Hotel, a stone's throw from Reddy's house. Yeddyurappa

wasn't taking any chances. During the 1999 elections, when he had got new suits stitched for a public appearance, he had suffered a rude shock when BJP had lost. For the last six-odd months, he was known as the "seven-day chief minister". Thus, it was only after 3 p.m., when the writing on the wall was clear, that a smiling Yeddyurappa surfaced to say that he was "humbled" by the victory. As his party members worked to cobble together a majority with the support of Independents, Governor Thakur invited him to form the next government of Karnataka, and Yeddyurappa found himself on history's threshold.

Not many leaders take oath of the same office twice in a span of six months. Before he was sworn in on May 30, Yeddyurappa had given a hint of the agenda of his Government.

While people in Karnataka—Bangalore in particular—are increasingly worried about issues as diverse as inflation and oil prices to internal security, there is much else that calls for urgent attention. Among the first meetings Yeddyurappa has scheduled is one with officers to study and implement the recommendations of the K. Kasturirangan committee on governance in the Bangalore metropolitan and the Greater Bangalore City Corporation regions. The report by the former Space Commission chairman and Rajya Sabha member calls for a paradigm shift from the previous policy of focusing on city-level urban local government to a metropolitan-level institution to enable better strategic planning and co-ordination. Yeddyurappa's top priority, therefore, is to set up a metropolitan planning

THE ALLURING PROMISE OF STABILITY, WHICH THE CONGRESS HAD MONOPOLISED FOR DECADES, HAS BEEN APPROPRIATED BY BJP AND TO DESIRED EFFECT.